

Resolving humanitarian crises
that arise from violent
crackdowns on civil protests

Social, Humanitarian & Cultural Issues (Third Committee)

Comăneci Corina-Nicoleta
~ Chairperson ~

Bâlcan Rareș-Ștefan
~ Chairperson ~

Table of contents:

- I. Introduction to the topic**
- II. Definition of key terms**
- III. Background information**
- IV. Major parties involved**
- V. Timeline of events**
- VI. Possible solutions**
- VII. Bibliography**



*"The arc of the moral universe is long, but it bends toward justice."
— Martin Luther King Jr.*

I. Introduction

Throughout history, the right to peaceful assembly has stood as a cornerstone of democratic societies and a fundamental human right enshrined in international law. Yet in nations across the globe, from Iran to Myanmar, Belarus to Syria, citizens exercising this basic right have been met with disproportionate force, mass arrests, and in the most extreme cases, lethal violence, needless to say this clear stepping over so many human rights at one have to stop for good. The scale of these crises demands urgent attention. In Iran, following the death in custody of Mahsa Amini in September 2022, nationwide protests were met with a crackdown that the UN Human Rights Chief described as resulting in "thousands" of deaths, including children.

These patterns are not isolated. From the 2014 crackdown on pro-democracy protests in Thailand to the 2021 military coup in Myanmar, from the ongoing repression in Belarus following disputed elections to the violent dispersal of protests across sub-Saharan Africa, governments consistently resort to force to suppress dissent. The humanitarian crisis arising are of most alarming and pressing importance and unignorable as they extend far beyond immediate casualties: injured protesters unable to seek medical care for fear of arrest, families unable to locate detained relatives, displaced populations fleeing violence, and lasting trauma that undermines social cohesion for generations.

The fundamental challenge remains: how can the international community respond effectively to humanitarian crises arising from violent crackdowns while respecting state sovereignty? How can accountability mechanisms be strengthened to deter future violations? And how can assistance be delivered to affected populations when governments block humanitarian access?

II. Definition of Key Terms

- **Peaceful Assembly**

The temporary but organized gathering of individuals for a common expressive purpose, conducted without violence. The right to peaceful assembly is protected by Article 20 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and Article 21 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights.

- **Violent Crackdown**

The use of disproportionate force by state security forces, including military, police, or paramilitary units, to disperse protests, suppress dissent, or punish protesters, often involving live ammunition, tear gas, beatings, mass arrests, and other forms of coercion.

- **Extrajudicial Killing**

The deliberate killing of individuals by state authorities without legal authorization or judicial process. UN Human Rights Council resolutions have specifically condemned extrajudicial killings in the context of protest crackdowns.

- **Enforced Disappearance**

The arrest, detention, or abduction of a person by state agents followed by a refusal to acknowledge the person's fate or whereabouts, placing them outside the protection of the law. This tactic is frequently employed to intimidate protesters and evade accountability.

- **Arbitrary Detention**

Detention imposed without legal basis or due process, including detention of peaceful protesters, detention incommunicado (without access to legal counsel or family), and detention beyond legally prescribed periods.

- **Fact-Finding Mission**

An independent investigative body established by the UN Human Rights Council to document human rights violations, collect and preserve evidence, and report findings with recommendations. The Independent International Fact-Finding Mission on Iran is a recent example.

- **Special Rapporteur**

An independent expert appointed by the UN Human Rights Council to monitor and report on human rights situations in specific countries or on thematic issues. Special Rapporteurs conduct country visits, receive individual complaints, and submit annual reports.

- **Communications Blackout**

The deliberate restriction or complete shutdown of internet and telecommunications networks by state authorities, often imposed during crackdowns to prevent protesters from organizing, documenting violations, and communicating with the outside world.

- **Universal Jurisdiction**

A legal principle allowing national courts to prosecute individuals for serious international crimes, such as crimes against humanity, regardless of where the crimes were committed or the nationality of the perpetrator or victim.

III. Background Information

Over the years patterns have been observed for these violent crackdowns and academic research and human rights documentation have identified consistent patterns in how states respond to protest movements with violence and are divided into phases as follows:

Pre-crackdown phase: Governments may declare states of emergency, restrict communications, deploy additional security forces to urban centres, and arrest opposition leaders pre-emptively.

Crackdown phase: Security forces use increasingly disproportionate force, from water cannons and tear gas to rubber bullets, live ammunition, and in some cases, heavy weapons. Medical facilities may be raided to arrest injured protesters. Mass arrests are conducted, often without warrants or with blanket charges.

Post-crackdown phase: Detainees may be held incommunicado, subjected to torture or ill-treatment, and tried before military or special courts with reduced due process. Families are denied information about detained relatives. Independent media and civil society organizations are suppressed.

Modern protest movements rely heavily on social media and messaging applications for organization and documentation. Consequently, states increasingly impose communications blackouts during crackdowns. During the January 2026 protests in Iran, authorities implemented "a near-total internet and telecommunications shutdown," making it impossible to verify casualty figures and preventing protesters from coordinating. One civil society representative described the situation as "the people of Iran remain in darkness".

IV. Major Countries and Organizations Involved

Syria

Since the unrest began in March 2011 in the Syrian Arab Republic, millions of women, men, girls and boys have been affected and suffered violations at the hands of warring parties. More than half the pre-war population has since fled, many multiple times, and more than 13 million Syrians are either displaced or living as refugees in one of the world's largest displacement crises. The Syrian civil war was an armed conflict that began with the Syrian revolution, when popular discontent with the Ba'athist regime ruled by Bashar al-Assad triggered large-scale protests and pro-democracy rallies across Syria, as part of the wider Arab Spring. The Assad regime responded to the protests with lethal force, which led to a series of defections, the emergence of armed opposition groups, and the civilian uprising descending into a civil war. The propagation of extreme violence, including mass atrocities and the displacement of populations, has significantly hindered efforts for peace, reconstruction, and development.

Myanmar

On 1 February 2021 a wave of resistance across the country has been triggered by the Myanmar military's decision to seize power. The response ousted the civilian government, including the country's leader, Aung San Suu Kyi. The coup triggered widespread demonstrations across major cities, with participants calling for the restoration of democracy and the release of detained leaders. However, the military responded with a brutal crackdown, resulting in hundreds of deaths and the detention of thousands of protesters, activists, and journalists. Despite the violence, many citizens, particularly youth, remained resolute in their calls for change, participating in strikes and documenting the military's actions. Meanwhile, some of the anti-coup activists have continued to have armed themselves in self-defense. International condemnation followed, leading to sanctions against military leaders, although support for the protests was also met with significant repression. By 2022, the situation escalated into a civil war, pitting the military against pro-democracy forces and various ethnic militias, resulting in widespread casualties and internal displacement.

Sudan

From April 2023 the ongoing conflict between the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces (RSF), has devastated civilian infrastructure, collapsed basic services and triggered the world's largest displacement crises, with an estimation of 13.6 million

people who are currently displaced, from which approximately 9.5 million internally displaced across all 18 states, and over 3 million who have fled to neighboring countries including Chad, South Sudan, Egypt, Ethiopia, Libya, and the Central African Republic. Sudan have been turned into the worst humanitarian crisis globally after nearly three years of continuous violence, severe access constraints, and reduced funding. An estimated 33.7 million people will need humanitarian aid this year. Over 24.6 million people face acute food insecurity, with famine now confirmed in el-Fasher (North Darfur) and Kadugli (South Kordofan), and over 20 additional districts across Darfur and Kordofan at serious risk. Moreover, the healthcare system has largely collapsed, with over 70% of facilities being non-functional in conflict zone and multiple disease outbreaks across all 18 states, with cholera, malaria, and dengue widespread.

Iran

Over the years, Iranian authorities have mismanaged access to essential services and failed to uphold people's economic, social and cultural rights, resulting in worsening living conditions and soaring inflation. As a result, to this, the Iranian people have always upraised and revolted, with the thought that something may change, but every time they tried, the government, throughout the Iranian Revolutionary Guard, have always cracked down violently, making multiples casualties and using unconventional methods, such as: torture, rape, public executions and arson. On December 28th 2025, protests erupted in Tehran, which quickly spread across the country and evolved into the most serious challenge to the Islamic Republic since the "Woman, Life, Freedom" movement in 2022 and 2023, after Mahsa Amini was killed by the "morality police". In the aftermath of the massacres of thousands by security forces on 8 and 9 January 2026, thousands more were arrested and a nighttime curfew was imposed in major cities, as heavily armed security forces patrolled the streets.

Venezuela

The humanitarian crisis in Venezuela has become one of the largest international displacement crises in the world with 7.9 million Venezuelans displaced globally. Following the announcement of the results of the presidential election in July 2014, people who have started protesting were violently repressed with excessive use of force and possible extrajudicial executions. The authorities intensified their policy of repression, including widespread arbitrary detentions on political grounds, enforced disappearances and torture.

V. Timeline of Events

Date	Description of event
17 December 2010	The self-immolation of Mohamed Bouazizi, which led to the Tunisian revolution and the beginning of the Arab Spring
25 January 2011	A violent crackdown starts in Egypt
15 February 2011	Protests in Benghazi (Libya) are met with live ammunition. It is the beginning of the First Libyan Civil War.
15 March 2011	Pro-democracy protests erupt in Daraa (Syria) and the Assad regime responds with siege tactics and mass arrests.
29 July 2011	The civil war starts in Syria
12 February 2014	The "La Salida" protests begin in Venezuela. As a response to them the Maduro government arrest the opposition leader Leopoldo López and several people are killed.
March 2016	A deal between Turkey and EU regarding migrants was announced
April – July 2017	The Supreme Court of Venezuela tries to limit the powers of the National Assembly and month of protests begins. The security forces use lethal force.
11 April 2019	Omar al-Bashir was ousted from presidency and placed under house arrest by the military as part of the Sudanese coup d'état.
1 February 2021	Protests begins in Myanmar as a response to a military coup that ousted the civilian government.
16 September 2022	As Mahsa Amini dies in the custody of "morality police", protests start in the entire country. The regime, throughout the Revolutionary Guard, launches a ruthless crackdown involving.
April 2023	The civil war starts in Sudan.
28 December 2025	New protests erupt in Iran
28 February 2026	Ali Khamenei dies in a US and Israeli missile strikes

VI. Relevant UN Treaties and Documents

- **UN Security Council Resolution 2417 (2018)**
- **UN Security Council Resolution 1296 (2000)**
- **UN Security Council Resolution 1674 (2006)**
- **UN Security Council Resolution 1894 (2009)**
- **2005 World Summit Outcome Document**
- **International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR)**
- **Convention against Torture and Other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment**
- **Basic Principles on the Use of Force and Firearms by Law Enforcement Officials**

VII. Previous Attempts to Solve the Issues

- **Diplomatic Initiatives and Peace Processes**

Diplomatic initiatives and peace processes have been employed to address the underlying grievances and conflicts that contribute to the violent crackdowns on civil protests. Negotiations and peace agreements aim to resolve political, ideological, and ethno-religious tensions that can be exploited by perpetrators.

- **Development and Reconstruction Programs**

Development and reconstruction programs have been implemented to address the socio-economic factors in order to help people reintegrate. These programs focus on promoting stability, governance, and socio-economic opportunities in regions affected by civil war.

- **Legal and Regulatory Frameworks**

Countries have voted and adopted legal and regulatory frameworks to criminalize genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing and crimes against humanity that can occur from crackdowns on civil protest. Such measures aim to disrupt the support networks and resources of perpetrators.

VIII. Possible Solutions

- Creating international early warning systems by closely monitoring human rights situations, the international community can step in early and try to prevent violent crackdowns before they happen.
- Implement an internationally agreed-upon legal framework to enable national prosecution regardless of where the crimes are committed.
- International mechanisms to maintain satellite internet and communications access during state-imposed blackouts are necessary to be able to keep in touch with people in affected areas.
- Medical facilities should be protected by law and unbiasedly given access to, and that can be ensured by international protocols and standardized protection of medical facilities during crackdowns.

IX. Sources

Background information

- <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC6876432/>
- https://www.sagepub.com/sites/default/files/upm-binaries/33557_6.pdf
- <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/73123/>
- <https://cisac.fsi.stanford.edu/mappingmilitants/profiles/islamic-state>

Countries and Organizations involved

- <https://www.britannica.com/event/Syrian-Civil-War>
- <https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/hrc/iici-syria/documentation>
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Syrian_civil_war
- <https://www.cfr.org/photo-essay/syrias-civil-war>
- <https://acleddata.com/report/myanmars-spring-revolution>
- <https://www.cfr.org/global-conflict-tracker/conflict/rohingya-crisis-myanmar>
- <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-64481138>
- [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Myanmar_protests_\(2021%E2%80%93present\)#](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Myanmar_protests_(2021%E2%80%93present)#)
- <https://www.who.int/news/item/09-01-2026-sudan-1000-days-of-war-deepen-the-world-s-worst-health-and-humanitarian-crisis>
- <https://news.un.org/en/focus/sudan-conflict>

- <https://reliefweb.int/report/sudan/sudan-crisis-situation-analysis-period-090326-150326>
- [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sudanese_civil_war_\(2023%E2%80%93present\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sudanese_civil_war_(2023%E2%80%93present))
- <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cjel2nn22z9o>
- <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/campaigns/2026/01/what-happened-at-the-protests-in-iran/>
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2025%E2%80%932026_Iranian_protests#bodyContent
- <https://www.britannica.com/event/2026-Iranian-Protests>
- <https://www.amnesty.org/en/petition/end-protest-massacres-in-iran/>
- <https://www.amnesty.org/en/location/americas/south-america/venezuela/report-venezuela/>
- <https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2014/country-chapters/venezuela>
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Venezuelan_refugee_crisis#
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Protests_against_Nicol%C3%A1s_Maduro#

Timeline of events

- <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/1/14/arab-spring-ten-years-on>

Relevant UN treaties and events

- [https://docs.un.org/en/s/res/2417%20\(2018\)](https://docs.un.org/en/s/res/2417%20(2018))
- [https://docs.un.org/en/S/RES/1296\(2000\)](https://docs.un.org/en/S/RES/1296(2000))
- [https://docs.un.org/en/S/RES/1674\(2006\)](https://docs.un.org/en/S/RES/1674(2006))
- <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/671118?v=pdf>
- <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/international-covenant-civil-and-political-rights>
- <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-against-torture-and-other-cruel-inhuman-or-degrading>
- <https://www.un.org/en/genocide-prevention/responsibility-protect/about>
- <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/basic-principles-use-force-and-firearms-law-enforcement>